IELTS Listening Module Guide

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Description

IELTS Listening has 4 parts and 40 questions, lasts about 30 minutes, and is the same for Academic and General Training. You hear each recording **only once**, and the answers come in the same order as the questions. Each correct answer is worth 1 mark, and your score is turned into a band from 0 to 9 (IELTS official).

Part	Situation	Speakers	Example
Part 1 (Q1–10)	Everyday social	Conversation between 2 people	Booking a hotel or a course
Part 2 (Q11–20)	Everyday social	1 main speaker	A talk about local facilities or a tour (maps often appear here)
Part 3 (Q21–30)	Education or training	2 main speakers, sometimes a tutor	Students discussing an assignment
Part 4 (Q31–40)	Academic	1 speaker	A university lecture

The parts get harder as you go. Accents include British, Australian, New Zealand and North American.

Extra time at the end: on the **paper-based** test you get **10 minutes** to transfer answers to the answer sheet. On the **computer-delivered** test you type answers directly and get only **2 minutes** to check them.

Types of questions

There are 6 official question types, and any part can use any of them.

Question type	What you do	How to handle it
Form / note / table / flow-chart completion	Fill gaps in a form, notes, a table or a process chart	Check the word limit, predict the type of word (number, name, noun), and write exactly what you hear
Multiple choice	Pick 1 answer from 3 options, or 2–3 answers from a longer list	Underline key words in each option; the speaker often mentions all options, so wait for the final decision
Matching	Match items (people, places) to a list of options	Read the option list first; listen for synonyms, not the exact words
Plan / map / diagram labelling	Label places on a map or plan, usually from a lettered list	Find the starting point (often the entrance) and follow the speaker's directions; see the Map section below
Sentence completion	Complete sentences that summarise the recording	Read the whole sentence so your answer fits grammatically

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Question type	What you do	How to handle it
Short-answer questions	Answer a question in a few words	Mark the WH word (who, when, where, how much) to know what to listen for

Word limits matter: if the instruction says **NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS AND/OR A NUMBER**, writing 3 words loses the mark. Hyphenated words such as “check-in” count as 1 word.

Attempting strategy

Prepare your rough sheet **while the instructions are being read out**, so you already know what kind of answer each blank needs before the audio starts.

1. On the rough-work paper, write the question numbers 1–40 in four columns, one column per part.
2. Look at each blank and ask which WH question it answers. Write that word next to its number: **When, Date, Time, Name, Why, What, Where, How many, Price, Object**.
3. While listening, you are now waiting for one specific thing (a date, a name, a number), which makes the answer much easier to catch.

Example rough sheet

Part 1	Part 2	Part 3	Part 4
1 Name	11 Where	21 Why	31 What
2 Date	12 Time	22 What	32 Object
3 Time	13 Price	23 Name	33 Why
4 …	14 …	24 …	34 …
10 …	20 …	30 …	40 …

If you miss an answer, don’t panic. Leave it, move straight to the next question and keep listening. Stopping to think about a missed question usually costs you the next two or three as well. At the end, guess the missed one sensibly; there is no penalty for a wrong answer, so never leave a blank.

Map labelling

Most learners find maps difficult, but they become easy once you know the location and direction words below. Two key ideas:

- **Location** = where something is in relation to another object or place.
- **Direction** = the way someone moves or faces.

How to attempt a map question

1. Before the audio starts, find the **starting point** (usually the entrance or “You are here”) and the **compass** (N, S, E, W).
2. Look at what is already labelled; the speaker will use those places as reference points.
3. Follow the speaker with your pencil on the map as they move. The answers come in number order.

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Common location words

Word	Meaning (Urdu)
near	قریب
in front of	سامنے
next to / by / beside	کے پاس
across from / opposite	پار، سامنے والی طرف
between	دو کے بیچ
behind	پیچھے

Common direction words

Word	Meaning (Urdu)
turn right	دائیں مڑیں
turn left	بائیں مڑیں
go straight on	سیدھے چلیں
travel northwest	شمال مغرب کی طرف جائیں
go past	آگے سے گزر جائیں

Vocabulary set 1 – Position

Words: **facing, in the middle / centre of, behind, between, next to / by, in front of**.

Example (university sports centre: entrance at the bottom, reception just inside, 25 m pool in the centre, gym at the back):

- The entrance is **in front of** the reception desk.
- The reception desk is **facing** the entrance.
- The pool is **in the centre of** the sports centre.
- The gym is **behind** the swimming pool.
- The pool is **between** the reception and the gym.
- The seating area is **next to / by** the pool.

Vocabulary set 2 – Sides and movement

Word	Meaning (Urdu)
left-hand side / right-hand side	بائیں / دائیں طرف
to your right	آپ کے دائیں طرف
pass through	گزرنا
on the other side (opposite)	دوسری طرف
beyond	اس سے آگے

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Word	Meaning (Urdu)
along	ساتھ ساتھ
corner	کونا
go straight / beside	سیدھے جائیں / پاس

Example (larger sports centre with a sports shop, café, leisure pool, sports hall and two dance studios):

- The sports shop is on the **left-hand side** as you enter the sports centre.
- To the **right-hand side** of the entrance, there's a café.
- **Pass through** the entrance, **turn right** and the café is immediately **in front of** you.
- The leisure pool is **on the other side** of the sports centre from the dance studios.
- There is a large changing room just **beyond** the café.
- Walk **along** the side of the sports hall and you'll find the second dance studio in the far **corner** of the building.
- **Go straight** along the corridor **beside** the sports hall, and **to your right** you'll see two dance studios.

Vocabulary set 3 – Compass directions

Words: **north, south, east, west, northeast, northwest, southeast, southwest**.

Phrases: **to the north / to the south, in the northeast / in the southwest, north side / east side / west side / south side, heading east, slightly west of, just southeast of**.

Other useful words: **near, first / second turning, on the left, straight ahead**.

Examples (a village map with a river, bridge, post office, primary school and retirement home):

- The houses **immediately to the north** and **south** of the post office are very **near** the river.
- The bridge is just **beyond** the final row of houses, **heading north**.
- After crossing the bridge, take the **second turning on the left** and you'll see the retirement home **straight ahead**.
- The retirement home is **just southeast of** the primary school.
- The post office is **to the northwest of** the retirement home.
- The village of Stokeford is **slightly east of** the River Stoke.
- There is a housing estate **to the west side** of the retirement home.

Vocabulary set 4 – Roads and streets

Word	Meaning
opposite / across the road	on the other side of the road
same side	on this side of the road too
before you get to	پہنچنے سے پہلے
junction	point where two or more roads join
dead end	a road that is closed at one end
leads off	starts from (another road)

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Examples:

- The chemist is **opposite** a supermarket.
- They are going to build new houses **across the road** from the school at point G.
- There is a supermarket on the **same side** of the road as the library.
- Walk west along High Street and you'll pass the library **before you get to** the **junction** with Station Road.
- The bank is on a **dead end** road that **leads off** the High Street.

Vocabulary set 5 – Extra words

Word	Meaning
bend	a curve in the road
just past	a short distance beyond a point
adjoining	next to or joined with
carry straight on	continue in the same direction

Do's and don'ts in the test

Do	Don't
Use the reading time before each part to read questions and mark the WH type	Don't spend the reading time checking the previous part's answers
Read the word limit for every set of questions	Don't write more words than allowed, even if the extra word seems helpful
Write answers in the booklet first, then transfer neatly (paper test)	Don't write answers straight onto the answer sheet while listening
Keep listening after you hear a possible answer, in case the speaker corrects it	Don't write the first number or option you hear without waiting
Move on immediately if you miss a question	Don't panic or keep thinking about the missed one
Guess every unanswered question at the end	Don't leave any blank; there is no negative marking
Check spelling, especially for names the speaker spells out	Don't change the words you heard into your own words
Write in CAPITAL LETTERS on the paper answer sheet if your handwriting is unclear	Don't mix styles or write so messily that letters look ambiguous
Bring a pencil and eraser (paper test)	Don't use pen on the paper answer sheet

Common traps

Most lost marks come from a few predictable traps, not from difficult listening.

Trap	What happens	How to avoid it
Distractors	The speaker says one answer, then corrects it: "The 14th… oh no, sorry, the 15th."	Wait for words like *actually, sorry, no, wait, instead* before writing

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Trap	What happens	How to avoid it
Paraphrasing	The question says “expensive”, the speaker says “it costs a fortune”	Practise synonyms; listen for meaning, not the exact words on the page
Spelling	A correct answer spelled wrongly gets no mark	Learn the spelling of common words (accommodation, Wednesday, February, necessary, environment)
Plurals	Writing “book” when the answer is “books” loses the mark	Check the grammar around the gap: “several ***”*** ***or “a*** ”?
Numbers	13 and 30, 14 and 40, 15 and 50 sound similar	Listen to the stress: thir-**TEEN** vs **THIR**-ty
Spelled names and letters	Letters like A/E/I, B/P/V, M/N get confused	Practise the English alphabet aloud; “double L” means LL
Word limit	“The city centre” is 3 words if the limit is 2	Drop articles if the answer still makes sense; “check-in” counts as 1 word
Losing your place	You miss one answer and then several more	Underline a key word in the next 2 questions so you can find your place again

Both British and American spellings are accepted (colour / color), but use one style consistently. Dates can be written in any common format (15 March, March 15th).

Useful links to practice

The **Cambridge IELTS books** are the most important resource: they contain real past papers, and question styles and topics often repeat in the live test. Practise at least one full listening test from them every week, then read the audioscript at the back to find what you missed.

Resource	What it offers
IELTS Master – Listening tests	Over 200 full listening practice tests online, plus a Cambridge tests section
KeenIELTS	Full Academic and General Training listening tests with instant scoring, answer keys and transcripts
British Council – free Listening practice	Sample tasks for every question type, including a map task, with answer keys and transcripts
British Council – computer test practice	A full 40-question listening test in the computer-delivered format
IELTS.org – sample test questions	Official sample questions from the test owners
IELTS.org – Listening format	Official explanation of every question type and word-limit rule
IDP IELTS	Preparation materials from the other main test provider
BBC Learning English	Short daily audio to build general listening and British accent familiarity

All resources above are free.

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